

NOVA

UI/UX Design Documentation

1. Project Overview

Introduction

University of Nova is a fully-featured, multi-page academic institution website built to deliver a premium digital presence for a modern fictional university. Spanning over ten interconnected HTML pages with a unified CSS design system, the site covers the full spectrum of a university's public-facing identity from prospective student recruitment and academic calendars to scholarship listings, alumni showcases, faculty directories, campus life pages, a detailed admission portal, and a fully functional five-step application form.

The site's tagline, "Excellence Redefined Daily," anchors both its brand voice and its design philosophy.

Website Name: University of Nova

Tagline: Excellence Redefined Daily

Type: Academic / Institutional (Multi-page static website)

Live URL: gargee1989.github.io/Nova/

Target Audience: Prospective students, current students, alumni, academic staff, partners, and the general public

Core Pages: Home, About Us, Admission, Academic Calendar, Academic Areas, Programs (4), Scholarships, Alumni, Faculty, Events, Campus Life, Contact, Apply Now

2. Design Philosophy

University of Nova's visual and interaction design is rooted in institutional authority balanced with warmth, aspirational energy, and navigational clarity. Every design decision reinforces the brand's identity as a leading modern university: rigorous and respected, yet welcoming and student-centered.

2.1 Academic Prestige & Heritage

The design language borrows deliberately from the visual traditions of established academic institutions -deep forest greens, warm gold accents, serif typography for display text, and high-quality architectural and campus photography.

- The deep navy-green primary colour (#1A221D) used in headers and footers evokes the gravitas of long-established institutions.
- Gold (#C9A84C) is applied purposefully as an accent — it signals prestige without ostentation.
- High-quality Unsplash photography of real university campuses grounds the fictional institution in visual credibility.

2.2 Clarity & Navigational Ease

Despite its rich visual palette, the site prioritizes informational clarity. Students need to find deadlines, program details, and application forms quickly. This is achieved through:

- A persistent sticky navbar with clearly labelled dropdown menus (Pages, Academics, Student Services).
- A top utility bar on inner pages showing phone, email, hours, and social links — ensuring contact information is always one glance away.
- Badge-style tags on the Academic Calendar (Academic, Deadline, Exam, Break, Holiday, Ceremony) that allow users to scan and categorize events without reading descriptions.
- Sidebar panels on Calendar and Apply Now pages that surface time-sensitive information (upcoming events, application deadlines, document checklists) at a glance without disrupting the main content flow.

2.3 Aspiration & Motivation

The website is designed not merely to inform, but to inspire. The Apply Now hero ("Begin Your Journey to Nova"), the scholarship framing ("Funding Opportunities — We believe financial barriers should never stand in the way of talent"), the alumni spotlight, and the animated counter blocks (students, alumni, employment rates) all function as motivational touch-points that invite prospective students to see themselves as part of Nova's story.

2.4 Consistency & Systematic Design

The site demonstrates a high degree of visual consistency through a shared design system:

- A unified CSS colour palette applied identically across all pages.
- The same navbar and footer HTML structure replicated on every page.
- Recurring section patterns: hero banner → ticker → content → CTA banner → footer.
- Consistent typographic hierarchy: large serif display headings with italic gold emphasis word, sans-serif body and UI text.

2.5 Accessibility & Inclusivity

The interface is designed for the broadest possible audience — including international students, users on mobile devices, and users with varying digital literacy.

- High contrast between the dark navbar and white page backgrounds ensures text legibility.
- Step-by-step progress indicators on the application form reduce cognitive load and prevent form abandonment.
- Form fields use explicit labels, required-field asterisks, placeholder text, and descriptive helper text (e.g. 'Use a personal email you check regularly').

- Language selector (ENG) in the utility bar signals multilingual readiness for international audiences.
- Campus tour accessibility note on the Contact page: 'All tours are fully accessible. Please let us know your requirements when booking.'

3. Colour Palette

The colour palette is deep, authoritative, and warm — drawing on the classic institutional palette of forest greens and academic gold while remaining contemporary and accessible. The off-white base (#F5F0EE) prevents the site from feeling cold or purely corporate. All CSS variables are defined globally and applied consistently throughout the site.

Variable	Hex Code	Role / Usage	Rationale
--navy	#1A221D	Primary navbar, footer, card headers, section backgrounds	Deep forest green-black — anchors the dark institutional identity throughout.
--navy-deep	#05250a	Hero overlays, deep background layers	Darker variant for full-bleed hero sections and depth behind light text.
--blue	#0a2805	Deepest background tints, hover states on dark elements	The darkest green (#0a2805) in the palette, used sparingly for layering and contrast depth.
--blue-mid	#224439	Secondary panels, sidebar backgrounds, mid-tone cards	Mid-tone green (#224439) between the primary dark and off-white; creates visual hierarchy in multi-section layouts.
--gold	#C9A84C	Primary CTA buttons, active nav states, badge outlines, icon accents	Warm academic gold, the primary brand accent, evoking prestige and distinction.
--gold-light	#f1c553	Hover states on gold elements, lighter badge variants	Brighter variant of gold for hover feedback and secondary accent use.
--white / --off-white	#F5F0EE	Page backgrounds, card surfaces, body text on dark backgrounds	Warm off-white — more comfortable for extended reading than pure white.
--light-gray	#465550	Dividers, input borders, secondary icon tints	Muted gray-green used for subtle separators and supporting

Variable	Hex Code	Role / Usage	Rationale
			UI elements.
--text-dark	#1A221D	Primary body text on light backgrounds	Same as navy — ensures text is always deeply legible on off-white surfaces.
--text-muted	#8F9897	Captions, metadata, placeholders, helper text	Low-emphasis colour for secondary information: event details, form hints, footer notes.

4. Typography

The typographic system pairs a classical serif display typeface with a highly legible sans-serif for body and UI text, creating a balance between scholarly character and functional readability.

4.1 Serif Display Typeface (Headings & Hero Copy)

An elegant serif typeface is used for all hero headings, page-level h1 elements, and major section titles across the website.

Classification: Serif (Display)

Usage: Hero titles ("University of Nova", "Begin Your Journey to Nova", "About Nova University"), major section headings ("Semester Two", "Available Awards", "Notable Alumni"), all h1 and h2 display elements

Italic Gold Accent Word: A recurring typographic device — one word per major heading is set in italics and gold (#C9A84C), e.g. 'University of Nova', 'Begin Your Journey to Nova', 'Available Awards', 'Notable Alumni'. This creates visual rhythm and branded identity across all pages.

Rationale: The serif display typeface carries the cultural weight of centuries of academic typography. Its use communicates intellectual authority and heritage, instantly positioning the site as belonging to the world of higher education rather than commerce or entertainment.

4.2 Sans-Serif Typeface (Body & UI)

A clean, geometric sans-serif is used for navigation labels, body copy, form fields, card descriptions, badge tags, and all functional interface text.

Classification: Geometric sans-serif

Usage: Navigation menu items, body paragraphs, event descriptions, scholarship details, form labels, dropdown option text, button labels, badge tag text, footer link columns, utility bar text, ticker content

Rationale: The sans-serif provides excellent legibility at small sizes and on screens, balancing the serif display typeface's classical character with practical clarity. Its geometric neutrality ensures

informational content — dates, deadlines, descriptions, fee amounts — is always easy to scan and never competes with the display type for attention.

5. Layout & Navigation

5.1 Global Header (Navbar)

A persistent sticky navigation bar appears at the top of every page, providing consistent wayfinding throughout the site. It consists of two layers:

- **Top Utility Bar (inner pages only):** A slim dark strip above the main navbar showing: phone number (+91 7865498765), email address (admissionsnova@university.edu), office hours (Mon–Fri, 9am–5pm), social media icon links (Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, YouTube), and an English language selector. Some pages show address (Nova Campus, Main Avenue) instead of or alongside the phone number.
- **Main Navbar:** Dark navy (#1A221D) background. Left: square logo badge (open book icon) + 'University of Nova' word-mark + italic subtitle 'excellence redefined daily'. Centre-right: navigation links and far right: gold 'Apply Now' button.
- **Pages Dropdown:** About Us, Faculty, Events, Campus Life, Alumni.
- **Academics Dropdown:** Three labelled sub-groups — Academics (Academic Areas, Academic Calendar), Admission (Requirements, Admission Process, Tuition Fee), Programs (Software Development, Creative Writing, Architecture Design, Cinematography).
- **Student Services Dropdown:** Scholarships only.

5.2 Page-by-Page Layout Summary

Each page uses a layout appropriate to its content type. The table below summarizes the layout strategy across all major pages:

Page	URL	Layout Pattern	Key Sections
Home	/index.html	Split hero + stacked content sections	Hero (dark left / photo right), animated stats counter, About blurb, Programs list, Campus Life grid, Faculty carousel, Testimonials, Events, CTA banner, Footer
About Us	/html/pages/about.html	Full-bleed hero +	Hero banner with breadcrumb, gold ticker

Page	URL	Layout Pattern	Key Sections
		scrolling content sections	bar (stats), Year Founded counter block, Our Story, Mission & Core Values (8 cards), Milestones timeline, Campus facilities, Accreditations, CTA, Footer
Admission	/html/admission.html	Anchored single-page with three sections	Hero + anchor nav (Requirements / Process / Tuition), Requirements (6 numbered items), 6-step Process timeline, Tuition fee tables (2 tables), FAQ accordion, CTA
Academic Calendar	/html/academic/calendar.html	Two-column: main list + right sidebar	Hero stats (2 semesters, 38 teaching weeks), scrolling event ticker, Semester One list, Semester Two list, mini calendar widget, sidebar with upcoming events + download CTA, Key Deadlines section
Scholarships	/html/studentservices/scholarship.html	Centred content + 3-column card grid	Hero breadcrumb, intro text, 3 scholarship cards (Provost Award / Global Citizen Grant / Future Innovators), 3-step How to Apply process, CTA banner
Alumni	/html/pages/alumni.html	Full-bleed hero + multi-section content	Hero, stats ticker, animated counters, Notable Alumni 4-column card grid, Featured Alumni spotlight (2-col), Industry breakdown (numbered list), Alumni

Page	URL	Layout Pattern	Key Sections
			Network benefits, CTA
Apply Now	/html/applynow.html	Hero + 5-step form with persistent sidebar	Hero, 5-step progress stepper, form panels (Personal Info / Academic Background / Program Selection / Documents / Review & Submit), sidebar (Application Deadlines + Checklist), Success confirmation screen
Contact	/html/Contact.html	Full-bleed hero + multi-section contact layout	Hero, Contact Information panel (address/hours/social), 6 department cards (phone + email), Visit Nova section with tour schedule, Footer

5.3 Recurring Section Pattern

Almost every page follows a predictable structural template:

- Hero banner (full-width, dark, with breadcrumb + h1 + subtitle)
- Gold ticker / marquee bar (scrolling stats or category labels)
- Main content sections (alternating white and slightly tinted backgrounds)
- CTA banner ("Begin Your Future at Nova University" — Apply Now + Explore Programs)
- Footer (dark navy, 3-column links + logo + social + copyright)

This predictability reduces cognitive load for repeat visitors and builds a strong sense of brand coherence across the site.

5.4 Footer

A consistent dark navy footer closes every page. It contains: the University of Nova logo and tagline (left), three quick-link columns — Our Campus (Academic Area, Events, Campus Life, Academic Calendar), Pages (About, Admission, Alumni, Faculty Staff), Quick Links (Apply Now, Scholarships, Requirements, Tuition Fees, Contact Us) — plus social media icons in gold, and a copyright line crediting 'Gargee & Kaustuva for academic excellence'.

6. Components & Interaction Design

The following table documents every recurring UI component across the site — what it looks like, where it appears, and how it is designed.

Component	Appears On	Design Details
Sticky Top Utility Bar	All inner pages	Dark navy strip; phone number, email, office hours (Mon–Fri 9am–5pm), social media icon links (Facebook/Instagram/LinkedIn/YouTube), language selector (ENG). Sits above the main navbar.
Main Navbar	All pages	Dark navy (#1A221D) background; open-book square logo icon + 'University of Nova' word-mark + italic subtitle 'excellence redefined daily'; nav links (Home, Pages ▾, Academics ▾, Student Services ▾, Contact); gold 'Apply Now' CTA button (right).
Dropdown Menus	Pages, Academics, Student Services nav items	Appear on hover; dark background panels. Academics dropdown has three sub-headings: Academics (2 links), Admission (3 links), Programs (4 links). Pages dropdown: 5 links. Student Services: Scholarships.
Marquee / Ticker	Home, About, Calendar, Scholarships, Alumni, Admission, Apply Now	Horizontally scrolling gold text on dark background; repeats key stats or category labels. Serves as visual separator between hero and content. Each page has unique ticker content.
Animated Counter Blocks	Home, About Us, Alumni	Large counter numbers that animate (count up) on scroll. Home: students/faculty/alumni/enrolled. About: years/alumni/faculty/partnerships. Alumni: graduates/countries/employment rate/C-Suite leaders.
Hero Banner	All pages except Home	Full-width dark overlay image. Breadcrumb path (Home > Section > Page) top-left. Large white serif h1 with gold italic word. Subtitle paragraph in off-white. Home hero uses split layout (dark left panel, campus photo right).
Event / Calendar Entry	Academic Calendar	Each entry: left-aligned date (bold number + day name), centre event title + description paragraph, right-aligned coloured tag badge. Tags: Academic (dark), Deadline (red-tinted), Exam (#224439-

Component	Appears On	Design Details
		tinted), Holiday (neutral), Break (neutral), Ceremony (gold-tinted).
Scholarship Card	Scholarships page	White card with gold icon (trophy/globe/chip), top-right badge tag (Merit Based / International / Innovation), bold heading, description paragraph, bullet benefit list with gold checkmarks, full-width gold 'Apply Now' button. Active/featured card has gold border.
Alumni Profile Card	Alumni page	Tall portrait image (full card height), overlay gradient at bottom, name in bold white, role in gold, social icons (3). Below image: degree info with graduation cap icon in muted text.
Faculty / Professor Card	Home page	Square photo, name in bold, title/role in muted text, three social icon links.
Multi-Step Form Stepper	Apply Now	Horizontal progress bar; 5 numbered steps: (1) Personal Information, (2) Academic Background, (3) Program Selection, (4) Documents & Essays, (5) Review & Submit. Active step highlighted in gold; completed steps have visual indicator; future steps muted.
Apply Now Sidebar	Apply Now	Persistent right panel (~35% width). Top card: Application Deadlines (4 items with coloured date badges — red for urgent/past, green for upcoming). Bottom card: Application Checklist (4 items: Official Transcripts, Government ID/Passport, English Test Results, Application Fee).
Calendar Sidebar	Academic Calendar	Right panel with 'Coming Up' dark card (upcoming events with month/day blocks), mini calendar widget with colour-coded legend, and 'Download the Full Calendar' dark card with gold CTA button.
Department Contact Cards	Contact page	6 cards arranged in a grid: Admissions, Academic Affairs, Student Services, Research Office, Careers & Alumni, Finance & Fees. Each shows phone number, email address, and operating hours.
Guided Tour Schedule	Contact page	Upcoming tour list with day/date block (abbreviated day name + number), tour title, description, time, and duration. Includes

Component	Appears On	Design Details
		accessibility note.
Footer	All pages	Dark navy background. Logo + tagline left; three link columns: Our Campus (4 links), Pages (4 links), Quick Links (5 links). Social icons in gold. Copyright line: 'Designed by Gargee & Kaustuva for academic excellence'.
CTA Banner Section	Most pages (bottom)	Full-width dark section: 'Begin Your Future at Nova University' heading, sub-paragraph, two buttons (Apply Now gold + Explore Programs ghost). Appears as final content section before footer on most pages.
Testimonial / Quote Block	Home page	Carousel or grid of student/faculty quotes. Quote mark icon, quote text, photo thumbnail, name in bold, role/class year in muted text.
Accreditation Badges	About Us page	Small dark cards in a horizontal row: QS World Rankings (Top 200), NAAC Accredited Business School, UN Academic Impact, NAAC+ Engineering, Government-Accredited Medical School.

6.1 Button System

Three distinct button types are used consistently across the site:

- **Primary CTA (Gold Fill):** Background #C9A84C, dark text label, slightly rounded corners. Used for the highest-priority action on any page: 'Apply Now' (navbar + hero + scholarship cards), 'Download the full calendar here', 'Submit Application'. Always the most visually prominent interactive element.
- **Secondary / Ghost (Dark Outline):** 'Explore Programs', 'Watch Video', 'Learn More', 'Register as Alumni'. Outlined or dark-fill variant, lower visual weight than primary. Used when a secondary action sits alongside a primary CTA.
- **Navigation / Anchor Pill:** Rounded pill buttons used for in-page anchoring on the Admission page (Requirements / Process / Tuition Fees) and for the semester date range badge on the Calendar page ('Jan – May 2027'). These indicate position or context rather than trigger actions.

6.2 Multi-Step Application Form

The Apply Now page features the site's most complex interactive component — a five-step wizard form that collects all admission data. Each step has its own form section; users move forward with 'Continue' and backward with 'Back'.

- **Step 1 — Personal Information:** Title (dropdown), First Name, Last Name, Date of Birth (date picker), Gender (dropdown), Email, Phone, Residential Address, Country of Citizenship (dropdown), Nationality, Emergency Contact (name, relationship, phone).
- **Step 2 — Academic Background:** Most recent institution name, country, qualification (dropdown), field of study, year of graduation (dropdown), GPA, grading scale (dropdown), optional SAT/JEE scores, honors/awards text area, extracurricular text area.
- **Step 3 — Program Selection:** Degree level toggle (Undergraduate / Postgraduate), first preference (faculty + program dropdowns), optional second preference, preferred intake (dropdown), study mode (dropdown), funding source (dropdown), Nova Scholarship option (Yes/No).
- **Step 4 — Documents & Essays:** File upload zones for Official Transcripts, Passport/National ID, English Proficiency Certificate, and up to 5 optional additional documents (max 5MB each, PDF/DOC/JPG/PNG). Referee email submission note.
- **Step 5 — Review & Submit:** Summary of all entered data (Personal, Academic, Program sections) with 'Edit' links per section. Three declaration checkboxes. Application fee notice (\$75 USD). 'Submit Application' button. On success: confirmation screen with reference number (NU-2026-XXXXXX) and download confirmation option.

7. References

- Nielsen, J. (1994). 10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design. Nielsen Norman Group. <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/>
- Kirkpatrick, A., O Connor, J., Campbell, A., & Cooper, M. (Eds.). (2025). Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1. W3C Recommendation. <https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/>